

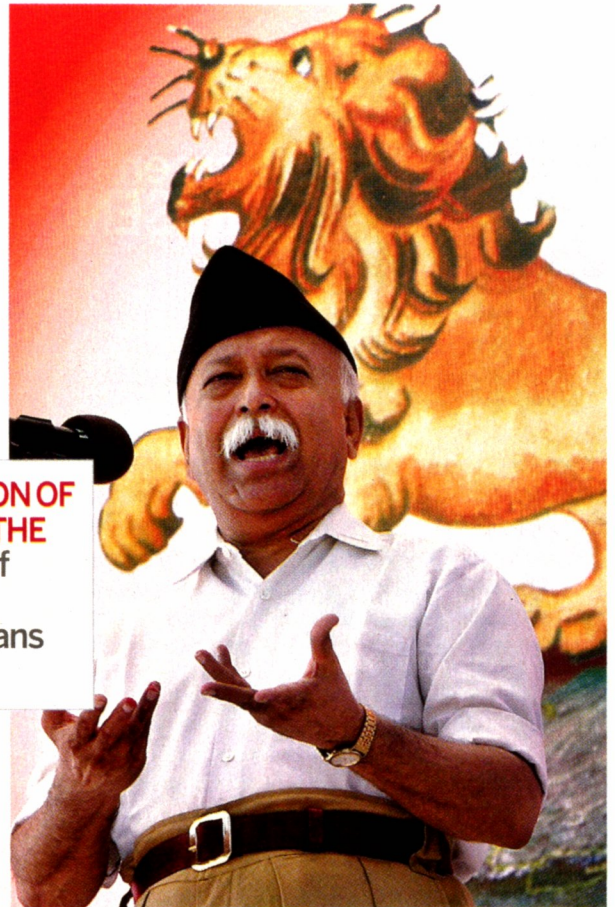
Mohan Bhagwat

Getting IT DONE

Even without his walrus moustache, Mohan Madhukarrao Bhagwat looks every inch the man who is there to crack the whip. Since he took over earlier this year as the RSS sarsanghchalak, Bhagwat has said and done things that aim at ideological correction. Three months ago, he created a flutter in the BJP by saying that the party was in urgent need of drastic surgery and asserted that the new party chief would not be from its established leadership. The elevation of Nitin Gadkari as the new party chief not only marks the end of the Vajpayee era, when the RSS played second fiddle to the BJP, but is also proof that Bhagwat means business. But challenges lie ahead, the most important of them being how to reinvent Hindutva, the Sangh Parivar's core ideology in the modern context and in a world that is getting increasingly globalised. He has so far tried to instill a young leadership even in the RSS. But he will have to take hard decisions, quick and fast, to get concrete results. Will he, for example, okay a proposal to change the khakhi shorts-white shirt RSS uniform to a modern T-shirt-pant?

by Uday Mahurkar

THE ELEVATION OF GADKARI AS THE new BJP chief is proof that Bhagwat means business.



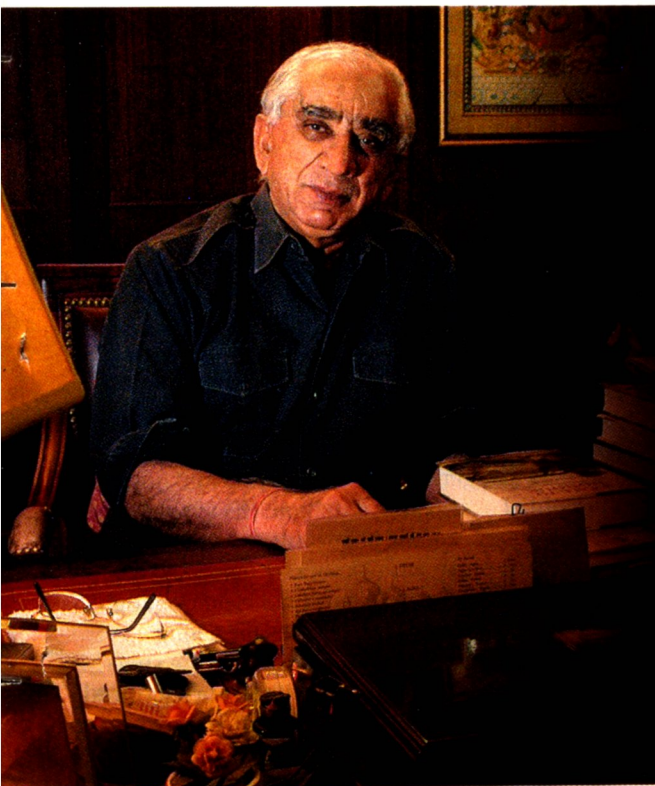
AP PHOTO

Jaswant Singh

Honourable REBEL

He was always prim, proper and forever coming to the defence of his party. But 2009 was the year when Jaswant Singh got very angry. The usually tranquil Thakur first stirred up a hornet's nest in the BJP by shooting off a missive seeking accountability for the Lok Sabha debacle. Then came his book on Mohammad Ali Jinnah, a man who had already claimed one scalp in the BJP in the recent past. Already uneasy with L.K. Advani's espousal of the controversial founder of Pakistan, the party was in no mood to indulge Singh's musings. In a knee-jerk reaction, it expelled him. As the year ends, Singh is back in the lexicon of a political debate, adding his bit to the demand for a Gorkhaland state, in keeping with the current political fashion of demanding separate statehoods. Even as the finance and external affairs minister in successive governments led by Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Singh was at best an interesting and active sub-plot. The partyless MP from Darjeeling continues to be just that.

by Priya Sahgal



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